

The Noble Sūtra of the Hurled Stone

Ārya-śīlākṣipta-sūtra · Toh 295 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་རྡོ་ཕངས་པའི་མདོ།

Toh 295 in the Kangyur is a sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-śīlākṣipta-sūtra and in Tibetan as the Phags pa rdo 'phangs pa'i mdo, rendered into English as The Noble Sūtra of the Hurled Stone. It belongs to the general class of canonical sūtra literature and recounts an episode in which the Buddha, wandering through the territory of the Mallas and resting in a dense grove of sal trees, instructs the Venerable Ānanda to accompany him toward the city of Kuśa. The narrative unfolds against the backdrop of a large assembly of Malla warriors gathered in council, suggesting the text is concerned with teachings or events arising from this dramatic social and political setting. As a canonical sūtra attributed to the direct speech of the Buddha, it is preserved among the sūtra collections of the Kangyur.

In the language of India: Ārya-śīlākṣipta-sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Noble Sūtra of the Hurled Stone. First fascicle.

Homage to the noble Mañjuśrī, ever youthful.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One had been wandering through the territory of the Mallas and came to rest in a dense thicket of sal trees — the dark thicket of sal trees.

Then the Blessed One said to the Venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, come here toward the city of Kuśa." "Venerable One, so be it," replied the Venerable Ānanda, and he followed the Blessed One's instruction.

Now at that time, the Mallas of the city of Kuśa numbered some five hundred warriors, and each of those warriors had a retinue of a hundred warriors each. Gathered and assembled in a certain meeting place, they spoke together in true words to this effect: "Friends, the Blessed One has been wandering through the territory of the Mallas and has come to rest in the dark thicket of sal trees. There, the Mallas born in that dark place paid homage to him with the finest of honors, offered the finest of offerings, and attended upon him with the utmost reverence fit for a teacher. And the Blessed One, for his part, bestowed upon them the supreme and sublime gift of Dharma, most excellent and unsurpassed, for their benefit. Now, as the Blessed One dwells there as he dwells, before long, surrounded by the assembly of monks, with the monastic

Saṅgha leading the way, he will depart for the city of Kuśa — the realm of our own village. So then, ought we not, for our own benefit, pay homage and offer offerings to the Blessed One? Let us therefore prepare the entire city of Kuśa in proper ceremonial fashion: let banners and pennants be hung, let the streets be well-swept and well-cleaned, and let everything be adorned with every manner of ornament and bunting, with incense, garlands, flowers, perfume, and the most beautiful sounds of music. Let parasols, victory banners, and flags be raised. Let festival days be observed. And the path along which the Blessed One is expected to travel — that road of passage too shall be prepared in proper ceremonial fashion with banners and pennants. From then on, all of us will do nothing but go forth to receive him." So thinking, they all assembled together with genuine joy, free from dispute, and with one purpose and one mind, they prepared the entire city of Kuśa in proper ceremonial fashion with banners and pennants. The streets were well-swept and well-cleaned, and everything was adorned with every manner of ornament and bunting, with incense, garlands, flowers, perfume, and the most beautiful sounds of music. Parasols, victory banners, and flags were raised. Festivals were observed. And the path along which the Blessed One had set out — that road of passage too was prepared in proper ceremonial fashion with banners and pennants.

Now at that time, between the city of Kuśa and the river Hiraṇyavatī, in a place where it had no business being, there stood a large broad stone lying right in the middle of the great road, rising visibly some fifteen fathoms high and eight and a half fathoms wide. Then they thought: "What if we were to lift this great broad stone from its present location and set it to one side? That way the road will be most beautifully prepared, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened Buddha will be honored, and the report, renown, and verse-praise of our great virtue will spread in all directions and quarters. Those who lift this great broad stone from its location and set it aside in whatever suitable direction —

"How wonderful! The champions of the city of Kuśa have shown courage! How wonderful! The champions of the city of Kuśa have shown themselves to be bold, possessed of bodies with the finest limbs, and endowed with the greatest strength!" — thinking thus, they reflected on it in this way and took their vows.

"O you who are wise, listen, you champions of the city of Kuśa, or you young sons of champions! I am resolved to strive to prepare this road. This great broad stone is lying where it should not be. It is obstructing the royal road.

Therefore I shall lift this great broad stone from this side and set it to one side. By doing so, we will have the road most beautifully prepared, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened Buddha will be honored, and the report, renown, and verse-praise of our great virtue will spread in all directions and quarters. Of those who lift this great broad stone from this side and set it to one side, it will be said: 'How wonderful! The champions of the city of Kuśa have shown courage! How wonderful! The champions of the city of Kuśa have shown themselves to be bold, possessed of bodies with the finest limbs, and endowed with the greatest strength!'"

Therefore, O wise ones, they all said "So be it — let us go to the great broad stone this very day!" and the champions of the city of Kuśa listened to one another. Then, each one mounted his finest steed, and thinking with pride "We are the most powerful on this earth," they came filled with arrogance over their lineage, their strength, their physique, and their lordly status, making loud and great noise, clamoring and shouting with excitement and glee, and with joy, happiness, and contentment arising in them. Setting out from the city of Kuśa with the greatest of grand retinues — horses, mares, the finest blue bulls, the best of herds, elephants, and many hundreds of fragrant elephants — they went to where the great broad stone lay. Arriving there, they wound it many times with strong, tough ropes of hide. Some rigged levers and pulled it this way and that with ropes of muñja grass, of balbaja grass, and with horse-traction ropes. Some wished to pry it from the ground with a hundred iron bars. Some wished to cut it with axes. Some wished to smash it to powder with vajra-hammers. Some wished to grip the edges with their own bodily strength and dislodge it entirely. Some wished to overturn it with the finest stallions and the best bulls. Some wished to break it apart by the force of a whole herd of cattle. Some wished to destroy it with the power of medicine. And some wished to make it vanish by the power of mantra. Yet with all that effort, exertion, and striving of theirs, as they set about lifting it from this side and setting it to one side, their bodies grew weary, their bodies grew exhausted, and their bodies bent low with supreme effort and became dispirited — they could not even budge the great broad stone, let alone raise or throw it.

Then the Blessed One, surrounded by the assembly of monks and with the Saṅgha of monks before him, set out toward the place where the great broad stone lay. The champions born in the city of Kuśa saw the Blessed One approaching from a great distance. And upon seeing him, they were delighted

and glad, and joy, happiness, and contentment arose in them.

Great reverence for their teacher arose in them all, and they went forward to receive the Blessed One. They bowed their heads to the Blessed One's two feet. They circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and having done so, they stood to one side in silence.

The Blessed One then spoke these words to the champions of the city of Kuśa standing to one side: "Young men, have you undertaken this with supreme great effort? Are you straining yourselves?"

When he had said this, the champions of the city of Kuśa replied to the Blessed One: "Reverend Sir, we champions of the city of Kuśa — we heard that the Blessed One had traveled through the domain of champions and gone to the evil one, that he had entered into the lotus grove where the evil insects dwell. There, the champions born in that evil place paid him the highest honor in the form of painted images, the highest offering, and the highest reverence toward their teacher. And the Blessed One in turn benefited them with the supreme, exquisite, unsurpassed gift of the Dharma. Now we have heard that the Blessed One, surrounded by the assembly of monks and with the Saṅgha of monks before him, is journeying to the city of Kuśa, our own home territory. And upon hearing this, all of us thought: how fitting it would be if we too were to honor the Blessed One with painted images and make offerings to him for our own benefit, and were to sweep and clean the entire city of Kuśa according to proper ceremony, setting everything in good order, and were to adorn it with every ornament and pennant, and then to deck it further with incense, garlands, flowers, perfumes, and the sweet sounds of music; to erect parasols, victory banners, and flags; to establish a festival day; and in whatever spot the Blessed One had walked with effort, to sweep and clean that very path according to proper ceremony. We thought: it will be best if all of us together simply go to receive him. And so we all gathered together, rejoiced in proper harmony, free from discord, single-minded and of one heart, and swept and cleaned the entire city of Kuśa according to proper ceremony, set everything in good order, adorned it with every ornament and pennant, with incense, garlands, flowers, perfumes, and the sweet sounds of music, erected parasols, victory banners, and flags, established a festival day, and swept and cleaned according to proper ceremony the very path along which the Blessed One had walked. And it was then that we saw the great broad stone lying where it had not been before, resting in the great open space. We then thought: let us lift this great broad stone from this side and set it to one side, whichever side may

be convenient — and then the road too will be very well swept, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the fully and perfectly awakened Buddha will be honored, and in all the cardinal and intermediate directions our great virtue will become widely renowned and celebrated in verse and song, and people will say, 'How brave are the champions of the city of Kuśa, who lifted that great broad stone from this side and cast it to the other.'"

"How wonderful — champions of the city of Kuśa have arisen, daring and bold, possessed of the finest bodily form, endowed with the greatest strength!" Thinking thus, they deliberated on the matter and resolved upon it. Then they said: "Wise ones, champions of the city of Kuśa, and you young sons of champions, hear us! We are striving to sweep this road clean. This great broad stone rests where it should not be and blocks the royal road. Therefore we shall lift this great broad stone from this side and set it to the other side. By doing so the road will be very well swept, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the fully and perfectly awakened Buddha will be honored, and in all the cardinal and intermediate directions our great virtue will become widely renowned and celebrated in verse and song, and people will say, 'How brave are the champions of the city of Kuśa — how daring and bold, possessed of the finest bodily form, endowed with the greatest strength, who lifted that great broad stone from this side and cast it to the other!' Therefore, O wise ones, let everyone come out now to where that great broad stone lies. So be it!" When they had spoken thus, each listened to the others in turn, and then each mounted his own fine horse. Filled with the conceit of thinking themselves the mightiest upon the earth, swollen with pride in their lineage, their strength, their physique, and their lordship, they came with loud voices and great clamor, shouting and making a din, pleased and delighted, joyful and happy and glad at heart. Setting out from the city of Kuśa in the greatest splendor, driving before them horses, she-camels, and the finest blue bulls, the finest of their herds, and many hundreds of elephants and perfume-bearing elephants, they went to where the great broad stone lay. They bound the great broad stone in every direction with strong ropes of twisted bark. Then some among them set up levers and tried to drag it hither and thither with ropes of muñja grass, of balvaja grass, and of horse-halter cord. Some wished to pry it up from the base with a hundred iron hooks. Some wished to cut it apart with battle-axes. Some wished to shatter it to powder by striking it with vajras. Some wished to press their lips together with the strength of their bodies and try to heave it by bodily force alone. Some wished to topple it with the finest

horses and the finest bulls. Some wished to crush it utterly with a host of elephants. Some wished to dissolve it by the power of medicine. And some wished to make it vanish by the power of secret mantra. Yet for all their striving, their pulling, and their effort, they could not in the slightest move that great broad stone from its place — let alone lift it up or hurl it to one side. After twenty-nine days of effort, with their bodies exhausted, their bodies worn out, their bodies bent and drooping, and their minds dispirited, they had been unable to move that great broad stone from its place entirely. How then could they lift it or hurl it away?

The Blessed One declared: "Young ones, does the Tathāgata wish to lift that great broad stone from its place and hurl it to the other side?"

"Most excellent Blessed One, we implore you! Most excellent Sugata, we implore you!"

Then the Blessed One drew his robe over one shoulder and —

approached the place where the great broad stone lay, and going to it, he moved the great broad stone with the big toe of his right foot, stirred it completely, and drew it out from its foundation without remainder. Taking it up with his left hand, he set it in the palm of his right hand, paused for a moment in contemplation, and then hurled it upward to the very world of Brahmā, where it came to rest, vanishing entirely from sight. At the sound of this, the assembly of wrestlers was struck with terror.

The Blessed One declared: "Young ones of stable lineage, do not be afraid. Simply by being hurled upward, all formations are impermanent, all phenomena are without self, and nirvāṇa is peace" — and he caused just such a sound to ring out. Then it came back, and that same stone came to rest in the very palm of the Tathāgata's hand. The Blessed One then reduced it to the finest dust with the breath of his mouth. And having made it into powder, he caused a rain of finest dust-particles to fall in every direction, in all the quarters and intermediate directions.

Then the assembly of wrestlers, seeing that the great broad stone was no more, became exceedingly distressed. Thereupon the Blessed One, with his mind knowing all, perceived the thoughts of that entire assembly of wrestlers, and understanding that they were exceedingly distressed at the absence of the great broad stone, he gathered and assembled from without every last particle of that stone-dust, without any loss or deficiency, and fashioned it once more into exactly that same great broad stone, and caused it to rest in a

solitary place to one side.

Then those five hundred or so wrestlers, drawn in by the Blessed One through these great and wondrous qualities, became filled with delight, joy, happiness, and contentment of mind, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what was that? Was it the power born of the Tathāgata's father and mother? Or was it the power of miraculous ability? Or was it the power of meditation? Young ones of stable lineage, the Tathāgata's moving the great broad stone with the big toe of his right foot, drawing it out from its foundation without remainder, taking it up with his left hand, setting it in his right palm, pausing for a moment in contemplation, and then hurling it upward to the very world of Brahmā — that is the power born of the Tathāgata's father and mother. Young ones of stable lineage, the Tathāgata's causing the great broad stone to resound with the words 'All formations are impermanent, all phenomena are without self, and nirvāṇa is peace' — that is the power of the Tathāgata's miraculous ability. Young ones of stable lineage, the Tathāgata's reducing the great broad stone to finest dust with the breath of his mouth, and then gathering and assembling that dust, every particle without loss or deficiency, and fashioning it into exactly that same great broad stone and causing it to rest in a solitary place to one side — that is the power of the Tathāgata's meditation."

"Venerable one, what manner of power born of father and mother do the Tathāgatas, those arhats, those perfectly and fully awakened buddhas, possess?"

"Young ones of stable lineage, do you wish to hear from the Tathāgata the power born of father and mother of the Tathāgatas, those arhats, those perfectly and fully awakened buddhas?"

"Venerable Blessed One, we implore you! Sugata, we implore you!"

"Young ones of stable lineage, therefore listen well, take it to heart, and I shall explain it to you. Young ones of stable lineage, the strength of ten men is equal to the strength of one ordinary bull. The strength of ten ordinary bulls is equal to the strength of one blue bull."

The strength of ten blue bulls is equal to the strength of one prime stallion. The strength of ten prime stallions is equal to the strength of one yak. The strength of ten yaks is equal to the strength of one rhinoceros. The strength of ten rhinoceroses is equal to the strength of one common elephant. The strength of ten common elephants is equal to the strength of one elephant

that does not trumpet. The strength of ten elephants that do not trumpet is equal to the strength of one elephant that trumpets greatly. The strength of ten elephants that trumpet greatly is equal to the strength of one single-tusked elephant. The strength of ten single-tusked elephants is equal to the strength of one blue-mountain elephant. The strengths of the yellow-mountain elephant, the red-mountain elephant, the white-mountain elephant, the finest-fragrance elephant, the gentle-fragrance elephant, the utpala-fragrance elephant, and the kumuda-fragrance elephant are likewise the same. The strength of one kumuda-fragrance elephant is equal to the strength of one lotus elephant. The strength of ten lotus elephants is equal to the strength of one great-lotus elephant. The strength of ten great-lotus elephants is equal to the strength of one elephant born in the snowy mountains. The strength of ten elephants born in the snowy mountains is equal to the strength of one elephant of the great-cluster wool-ox fragrance kind. The strength of ten elephants of the great-cluster wool-ox fragrance kind is equal to the strength of one great-cluster half-being. The strength of two great-cluster half-beings is equal to the strength of one great-cluster being. The strength of ten great-cluster beings is equal to the strength of one supreme-subduer half-being. The strength of two supreme-subduer half-beings is equal to the strength of one supreme-subduer. The strength of ten supreme-subduers is equal to the strength of one supreme power. The strength of ten supreme powers is equal to the strength of one supreme-limbed being. The strength of ten supreme-limbed beings is equal to the strength of one half son of Nanda. The strength of two half sons of Nanda is equal to the strength of one son of Nanda. Three hundred and twenty times the strength of a son of Nanda is equal to the strength born of father and mother of one Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha. Why is this? Because the Tathāgatas, those arhats, those perfectly and fully awakened buddhas, bear the strength of a son of Nanda in each and every point of their bodies.

All those who have passed, all those yet to come, and I myself as a Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha arising now in the present — all buddhas are equal in equality: equal in their major marks, equal in the equivalence of qualities, and equal in the maturation of the fruit of merit. But they are not equal in the three causes of lineage, lifespan, and bodily form. The Tathāgatas, those arhats, those perfectly and fully awakened buddhas who are of stable lineage, possess such strength born of father and mother.

And all those who have passed, all those yet to come, and I myself as a Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha arising now in the present — all buddhas are equal in equality: equal in their major marks, equal in the equivalence of qualities, and equal in the maturation of the fruit of merit. But they are not equal in the three causes of lineage, lifespan, and bodily form.

"Venerable one, Blessed One, as for the strength born of father and mother that belongs to the Tathāgatas, those arhats, those perfectly and fully awakened buddhas — we have heard of it. Venerable one, what manner of strength of merit do those Tathāgatas, those arhats, those perfectly and fully awakened buddhas possess? Lineages of stability, do you wish to hear from you, the Tathāgata, of the strength of merit of the Tathāgatas, those arhats, those perfectly and fully awakened buddhas?"

"Venerable Blessed One, we implore you most earnestly. Sugata, we implore you most earnestly."

"Lineages of stability, therefore listen well and hold this in mind; I shall explain. Lineages of stability, even if one were to reckon precisely all the merit of the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa and compare it to the merit of the wheel-turning sovereign who is lord of one continent, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Lineages of stability, even if one were to reckon precisely all the merit of the sentient beings of two continents and compare it to the merit of the wheel-turning sovereign who is lord of two continents, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Lineages of stability, even if one were to reckon precisely all the merit of the sentient beings of three continents and compare it to the merit of the wheel-turning sovereign who is lord of three continents, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Lineages of stability, even if one were to reckon precisely all the merit of the sentient beings of four continents and compare it to the merit of the wheel-turning sovereign who is lord of four continents, it would not come

within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Lineages of stability, there have arisen four wheel-turning sovereigns: the sovereign of one continent, the sovereign of two continents, the sovereign of three continents, and the sovereign of four continents. Of these, the wheel of the wheel-turning sovereign of one continent is made of iron and extends a single league in circumference. The wheel of the wheel-turning sovereign of two continents is made of copper and extends two leagues in circumference. The wheel of the wheel-turning sovereign of three continents is made of silver and extends three leagues in circumference. The wheel of the wheel-turning sovereign of four continents is made of gold, with a thousand spokes together with a hub and a rim, all fashioned from gold, radiating the light of divine substances, blazing with brilliant luminosity, and extending four leagues in circumference.

Lineages of stability, even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the wheel-turning sovereigns of four continents — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the gods of the heaven of the Four Great Kings, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the gods of the heaven of the Four Great Kings — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the four Great Kings themselves, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation."

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Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the four Great Kings — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of Śakra (Indra), Lord of Gods, it would not come within

even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of Śakra, Lord of Gods — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the gods of the Heaven Free from Strife, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the gods of the Heaven Free from Strife — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the divine son Utterly Free from Strife, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the divine sons Utterly Free from Strife — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the gods of Tuṣṭita, the Heaven of Joy, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the gods of Tuṣṭita — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the divine son Perfectly Joyful in Tuṣṭita, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the divine sons Perfectly Joyful in Tuṣṭita — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the gods of the Heaven Delighting in Emanation, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the gods of the Heaven Delighting in Emanation — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the divine son Supremely Delighting in Emanation, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the divine sons Supremely Delighting in Emanation — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the gods who Wield Power over Others' Emanations, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the gods who Wield Power over Others' Emanations — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the divine son Sovereign, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the divine sons Sovereign — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of the gods of the Brahmā realms, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

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Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the gods of the Brahmā realms — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of Brahmā, Lord of the Blissful Wheel, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

And so it is likewise for each of the following levels of the Brahmā realms in relation to the one above it: the Brahmā Priests, the Great Brahmās, the Gods of Minor Light, the Gods of Measureless Light, the Gods of Radiant Light, the Gods of Minor Virtue, the Gods of Measureless Virtue, the Gods of Vast Virtue, the Cloudless Gods, the Merit-Born Gods, the Gods of Great Fruit, the Gods Not Great, the Unafflicted Gods, the Splendid Appearing Gods, the Clearly Seeing Gods — and so too for the Akaniṣṭha Gods. Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of the Akaniṣṭha Gods — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of a single rhinoceros-like pratyekabuddha (a solitary buddha who, like a rhinoceros, practices alone), it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of pratyekabuddhas — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of a single bodhisattva Maitreya (Loving-Kindness), it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of bodhisattvas Maitreya — merit amounting to a hundred thousand ten-millions — and compare it to the merit of a single bodhisattva of the last existence, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

Even if one were to reckon precisely the merit of bodhisattvas of the last existence equal in number to the grains of sand in the Ganges River, and compare it to the merit of a single Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, it would not come within even a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation.

O you of the lineage of the Settled Abode, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened Buddhas are endowed with such a power of merit. All the Buddhas — those of the past, those of the future, and those who, like myself, are Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened Buddhas arising at this present time — are equal to one another, equal in their defining marks, equal in their matching qualities and attributes, equal in the maturation of merit's fruit. They are not equal, however, in the three causes of lineage, lifespan, and bodily form.

Then the assembly spoke: "Venerable one, we have heard from the Tathāgata of the power that arises from the father and mother of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddhas. We have heard of the power of merit. Now, Venerable one, what power of wisdom do the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddhas possess?"

And those of the lineage of the Settled Abode asked: "Do you wish to hear from the Tathāgata the power of wisdom of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddhas?"

"Venerable Blessed One, we earnestly request it. O Sugata, we earnestly request it."

The Blessed One then said: "Therefore, you of the lineage of the Settled Abode, listen well and hold it in mind — I shall explain. O you of the lineage of the Settled Abode, the great ocean has a depth of eighty thousand leagues.

that immeasurable expanse filled to the brim with ink-essence, and the king of mountains, Mount Meru, rising visibly eighty thousand leagues above the water, fashioned from four precious substances and having four faces — the first face made of gold, the second face made of silver, the third face made of beryl (*vaidūrya*), the fourth face made of crystal. On the golden face appears the reflection of the northern continent Uttarakuru; on the silver face appears the reflection of the eastern continent Videha; on the beryl face appears the reflection of Jambudvīpa; and on the crystal face appears the reflection of the western continent Aparagodānīya. Mount Meru, eighty thousand leagues of it, sinks down beneath the water, and all of that which lies between its golden-faced side and the surface of the earth becomes like a sheet of chaff. As for all the sentient beings of the four continents — their scribes are that many. And every grass, tree, branch, and twig upon the great earth — these become that many pens. Then the lineages of the Settled Abode having as their source of ink an ocean as vast as the great ocean, as their chaff-sheets a pile as tall as Mount Meru, as their scribes a number equal to all the sentient beings of the four continents, and as their pens a count equal to every grass, tree, branch, and twig upon the great earth — even with all of these most quickly exhausted and worn through, I do not say that the wisdom of the monk Śāriputra would be exhausted. You of the lineage of the Settled Abode, the monk Śāriputra is endowed with just such a power of wisdom.

You of the lineage of the Settled Abode, consider this: the suns of Vairocana (the Illuminator) travel everywhere and light up all directions. In a world-system of one thousand, there are one thousand moons, one thousand suns, one thousand kings of mountains called Meru, one thousand eastern continents of Videha, one thousand western continents of Aparagodānīya, one thousand northern continents of Uttarakuru, one thousand Jambudvīpas, one thousand realms of the gods of the Four Great Kings, one thousand realms of the gods of the Thirty-Three, one thousand realms of the gods Free from Strife, one thousand realms of the Joyful Gods (*Tuṣita*), one thousand realms of the gods who Delight in Emanation, one thousand realms of the gods who Wield Power over Others' Emanations, and one thousand Brahmā worlds. This is called the small world-system of one thousand. One thousand of these small world-systems of one thousand constitute what is called the middling

world-system of two thousand. One thousand of these middling world-systems of two thousand constitute what is called the great trichiliocosm, the vast world-system of three thousand times three thousand.

You of the lineage of the Settled Abode, even if that great trichiliocosm were filled to the brim with beings of wisdom equal to that of the monk Śāriputra, and one were to investigate it as the wisdom of a Tathāgata, it would not come even to within one hundredth part. It would not come within one thousandth part, one hundred-thousandth part, any measure, any fraction, any count, any analogy, or any proportion whatsoever.

You of the lineage of the Settled Abode, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddhas are endowed with just such a power of wisdom — all the Buddhas of the past, all the Buddhas of the future, and all those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened Buddhas who have now arisen in the present are equal and equal: equal in marks, equal and matching in qualities, equal in the matured fruit of merit. They are not, however, equal in the three factors of lineage, lifespan, and body.

"Venerable one, we have heard from you about the power arising from the father and mother of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddhas. We have heard of the power of merit. We have heard of the power of wisdom. Venerable one, what manner of miraculous power (ṛddhi-bala) do the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddhas possess? You of the lineage of the Settled Abode, do you wish to hear from the Tathāgata about the miraculous power of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddhas?"

"Venerable one, Blessed One, we entreat you most earnestly. Sugata, we entreat you most earnestly."

"You of the lineage of the Settled Abode, therefore listen well, take it to heart, and I will speak."

"You of the lineage of the Settled Abode, this is one such occasion. I was dwelling at the foot of a rough-trunked tree in a place with vīraṇa grass, in a region as harsh as a yakṣa's swamp. And at that time, in that place with vīraṇa grass, a famine had arisen in that difficult, desolate wilderness — a place where wandering mendicants found it hard to obtain alms — and the monks were utterly exhausted from the poor quality of the food.

Then the monk Maudgalyāyana came to where I was, approached me, and spoke to me thus: 'Venerable one, just now in this place with vīraṇa grass, a famine has arisen in this difficult, desolate wilderness where wandering mendicants find it hard to obtain alms, and the monks are utterly exhausted from the poor summer food. Venerable one, I have heard and received this directly from the Blessed One: beneath this great earth there lies a most excellent stratum of elemental essence born of the earth. I see and enter into a correct understanding of this through my own direct knowledge. For this very reason, venerable one, I wish to overturn this great earth — to bring that most excellent stratum of elemental essence born of the earth that lies beneath up to the top, and to send what is on top down below.'

To this I declared: 'Maudgalyāyana, do you wish to overturn the great earth?' He replied: 'Venerable one, I wish to overturn the great earth.' I declared: 'Dwelling here, do you wish to overturn the great earth?' He replied: 'Venerable one, dwelling in this place and in the surrounding great expanse, I wish to overturn the great earth.' I then declared: 'Maudgalyāyana, if you wish to overturn the great earth, what will you do with the sentient beings and living creatures that depend upon the earth?' He replied: 'Venerable one, I wish to overturn the great earth. I will take up those sentient beings and living creatures that depend upon the earth and hold them in my left hand, and with my right hand I will overturn the great earth.' I then declared: 'Maudgalyāyana, when you overturn the great earth, what kind of perception will you hold?' He replied: 'Venerable one, when I overturn the great earth, I will hold the highest and most weightless perception — just as a strong man turning over a water-lily leaf holds the highest and most weightless perception. In the same way, venerable one, when I overturn the great earth, I will hold the highest and most weightless perception.'

To this I declared: 'Maudgalyāyana, excellent! Excellent!'"

"Maudgalyāyana, even if you were able to overturn the great earth by that miracle power and by that method, the Tathāgata would not grant you permission to overturn the great earth. Maudgalyāyana, why is that? Because most sentient beings are attached to the taste of food, confused by the taste of food, and would become utterly deluded. Maudgalyāyana, why is that? Because the excellent element of taste arising from the earth, found upon the great earth, would not remain for long — without much delay it would vanish entirely from the great earth, everywhere and in every way. Therefore those sentient beings, spirits, and living creatures, being attached to the taste of

food and confused by the taste of food, would become utterly intoxicated, or their life-force would be cut and they would meet the time of death. Maudgalyāyana, for that reason the Tathāgata would not grant you permission to overturn the great earth."

Those established in the continuum, the monk Maudgalyāyana is endowed with such power of miracle working.

Those established in the continuum, it is like this: as the illuminating suns course along, they cause the directions to be lit. So long as that endures, in a world of one thousand there are one thousand moons, one thousand suns, one thousand king-of-mountains Mount Merus, one thousand Videhas of the East, one thousand Godānīyas of the West, one thousand Uttarakurus of the North, one thousand Jambudvīpas, one thousand gods of the four great divine kings, and the gods of the Thirty-Three, the gods free from strife, the Joyful Ones, those who delight in emanation, and the gods who wield power over others' emanations, together with one thousand Brahmā worlds — this is called the world-system of one thousand, the very first thousand. One thousand of those world-systems of the first thousand is called the intermediate world-system of two thousand. One thousand of those intermediate world-systems of two thousand is called the great world-system of the three-thousand-great-thousand.

This is the second and final fascicle of the noble sūtra "The Thrown Stone."

Those established in the continuum, that great world-system of the three-thousand-great-thousand would be filled with monks like Maudgalyāyana who are endowed with miracle power, and yet even if one were to precisely enact the Tathāgata's miracle power, it would not come even close to a hundredth part of it. It would not come close even to a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, by number, by fraction, by counting, by example, or by analogy. Why is that? Because the miracle power of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas moves by way of the body, whereas the miracle power of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha is swift as thought. Those established in the continuum, Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are endowed with such power of miracle working. All buddhas — those who have passed, those yet to come, and those who, like myself, have awakened as Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas in the present time — are equal to one another, equal in their marks, equal in their qualities, and equal in the maturation of the fruit of merit. They

are not, however, equal in three causes, namely lineage, lifespan, and bodily form.

"Venerable one, we have heard from the Tathāgata of the power arising from the father and mother of perfectly and fully awakened Tathāgata buddhas, and we have heard of the power of merit, and we have heard of the power of wisdom, and we have heard of the power of miracle working.

"Venerable one, with what kind of power of meditation are Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas endowed? O lineages of the steadfast, do you wish to hear from the Tathāgata the power of meditation of Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas?" "Venerable one, we entreat the Blessed One most earnestly. We entreat the Sugata most earnestly." "O lineages of the steadfast, therefore listen well and take it to heart, for I shall explain. O lineages of the steadfast, Jambudvīpa measures seven thousand yojanas across the water; it is broad to the north and shaped like a chariot in the south. O lineages of the steadfast, the eastern continent of Videha measures eight thousand yojanas across the water and is crescent-shaped. O lineages of the steadfast, the continent of Godānīya measures nine thousand yojanas across the water and is perfectly circular. O lineages of the steadfast, the northern continent of Uttarakuru measures ten thousand yojanas across the water and is square on all sides.

"O lineages of the steadfast, there is a time when a great timeless cloud arrives and settles over all four continents. At that time, from the four great continents, great streams of water and great masses of water pour down into the great ocean. Now, as for each individual water-drop of the Tathāgata — he fully examines it, ascertaining: 'This water-drop rains down from Jambudvīpa, from great cities, from great market towns, from great provinces, from great provincial regions, from great forest groves, from great tree trunks, from branches, from leaves, from flowers, from fruits, from grasses, from trees, from boughs, and from great logs.' And: 'This rains down from Godānīya, from Videha, and from Uttarakuru — from great cities, from great market towns, from great provinces, from great provincial regions, from great forest groves, from great tree trunks, from branches, from leaves, from flowers, from fruits, from grasses, from trees, from boughs, and from great logs.' He fully examines each such water-drop even down to the level of the finest particle.

"O lineages of the steadfast, such is the power of meditation with which Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are endowed. All

buddhas — those who have passed, those yet to come, and those who, like myself, have awakened as Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas in the present time — are equal to one another, equal in their marks, equal in their qualities, and equal in the maturation of the fruit of merit. They are not, however, equal in the three causes, namely lineage, lifespan, and bodily form.

"O lineages of the steadfast, Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are endowed with yet another set of qualities, namely the ten powers. They occupy the supreme station of the bull of the herd, and roar aloud the lion's roar truly and rightly in the midst of the assembly while turning the Brahmā wheel perfectly. And all buddhas — those who have passed, those yet to come, and those who, like myself, have awakened as Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas in the present time — are equal to one another, equal in their marks, equal in their qualities, and equal in the maturation of the fruit of merit. They are not, however, equal in the three causes, namely lineage, lifespan, and bodily form.

"O lineages of the steadfast, what are the ten powers with which they are endowed?"

In this regard, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, what is a proper occasion and what is not a proper occasion. O lineages of the steadfast, it is thus: the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, what is a proper occasion and what is not a proper occasion. O lineages of the steadfast, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are endowed with that first power, and they take up the great station of the foremost of herds, opening wide their mouth and roaring the lion's roar truly and rightly in the midst of the assembly while turning the Brahmā wheel perfectly.

O lineages of the steadfast, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the occasion, cause, substance, and karmic maturation pertaining to past, future, and present actions and to those phenomena that are rightly undertaken. O lineages of the steadfast, it is thus: the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the occasion, cause, substance, and karmic maturation pertaining to past, future, and present actions and to those phenomena that are rightly undertaken. O

lineages of the steadfast, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are endowed with that second power, and they take up the great station of the foremost of herds, opening wide their mouth and roaring the lion's roar truly and rightly in the midst of the assembly while turning the Brahmā wheel perfectly.

O lineages of the steadfast, furthermore the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the defilement and the purification, the stability and the thorough purity pertaining to meditative concentrations (dhyāna), liberations, meditative absorptions (samādhi), and meditative attainments. O lineages of the steadfast, it is thus: the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the defilement and the purification, the stability and the thorough purity pertaining to meditative concentrations, liberations, meditative absorptions, and meditative attainments. O lineages of the steadfast, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are endowed with that third power, and they take up the great station of the foremost of herds, opening wide their mouth and roaring the lion's roar truly and rightly in the midst of the assembly while turning the Brahmā wheel perfectly.

O lineages of the steadfast, furthermore the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the supreme and non-supreme faculties of other sentient beings and other persons. O lineages of the steadfast, it is thus: the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the supreme and non-supreme faculties of other sentient beings and other persons. O lineages of the steadfast, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are endowed with that fourth power, and they take up the great station of the foremost of herds, opening wide their mouth and roaring the lion's roar truly and rightly in the midst of the assembly while turning the Brahmā wheel perfectly.

O lineages of the steadfast, furthermore the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the manifold variety of the inclinations of other sentient beings and other persons. O lineages of the steadfast, it is thus: the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the manifold variety of the inclinations of other sentient beings and other persons. O lineages of the steadfast, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully

awakened buddhas are endowed with that fifth power, and they take up the great station of the foremost of herds, opening wide their mouth and roaring the lion's roar truly and rightly in the midst of the assembly while turning the Brahmā wheel perfectly.

O lineages of the steadfast, furthermore the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the world possessed of many and various elements and constituents. O lineages of the steadfast, it is thus: the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the world possessed of many and various elements and constituents. O lineages of the steadfast, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are endowed with that sixth power, and they take up the great station of the foremost of herds, opening wide their mouth and roaring the lion's roar truly and rightly in the midst of the assembly while turning the Brahmā wheel perfectly.

O lineages of the steadfast, furthermore the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the paths that lead to every destination. O lineages of the steadfast, it is thus: the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas perfectly and completely know, just as it is, the paths that lead to every destination. O lineages of the steadfast, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are endowed with that seventh power, and they take up the great station of the foremost of herds, opening wide their mouth and roaring the lion's roar truly and rightly in the midst of the assembly while turning the Brahmā wheel perfectly.

O lineages of the steadfast, furthermore the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas recollect their many and various former abodes truly and completely — that is to say: one lifetime, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine, ten, twenty, thirty, forty, fifty, a hundred lifetimes, a thousand lifetimes, a hundred thousand lifetimes, many hundreds of lifetimes, many thousands of lifetimes, many hundreds of thousands of lifetimes, an aeon of destruction, an aeon of formation, an aeon of destruction and formation, many aeons of destruction, many aeons of formation, and many aeons of destruction and formation — recollecting them together with their features and their specific places and directions, and recalling that those sentient beings who arose there bore such and such names, that we too bore such and such names there, that the clans were thus and thus, the lineages were thus and thus, the food eaten was of such and such kinds, the pleasures and sufferings

experienced were of such and such kinds, the lifespan extended so long, the duration of residence was so long, the span of life was so much — and that those beings and we ourselves, passing away from that place, were born somewhere or other, and passing away thence were again born somewhere or other, and passing away thence were born here once more.

— together with the basis from which all this arose — they perfectly recall in full detail their many former lives. Such are the continuity-threads of abiding. For thus the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas perfectly recall their many former lives: one lifetime, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine, ten, twenty, thirty, forty, fifty, a hundred lifetimes, a thousand lifetimes, a hundred thousand lifetimes, many hundreds of lifetimes, many thousands of lifetimes, many hundreds of thousands of lifetimes, an aeon of dissolution, an aeon of formation, an aeon of both dissolution and formation, many aeons of dissolution, many aeons of formation, and many aeons of both dissolution and formation — perfectly recalling all of these, and recalling that those sentient beings who arose there bore such and such names, that we too bore such and such names there, that the clans were thus and thus, the lineages were thus and thus, the food eaten was of such and such kinds, the pleasures and sufferings experienced were of such and such kinds, the lifespan extended so long, the duration of residence was so long, the span of life was so much — and that those beings and we ourselves, passing away from that place, were born somewhere or other, and passing away thence were again born somewhere or other, and passing away thence were born here once more — all of this together with its specific features, its specific locations, and the basis from which it all arose, they perfectly recall in full detail their many former lives. Such are the continuity-threads of abiding. The Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas are endowed with this eighth power; and, taking up the great exalted station of the foremost among herds, they turn the noble brahmic wheel and within the assembly roar the lion's roar in all its fullness.

Moreover, such are the continuity-threads of abiding — the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, with the divine eye that is purified and surpasses that of humans, behold sentient beings as they pass away and are born, beautiful and ugly, high and low, faring to the happy realms and faring to the wretched ones. And with precise discernment into sentient beings as they actually are, drawing near to those beings as they truly are, they know fully: those sentient beings who conduct themselves

wrongly in body, who conduct themselves wrongly in speech and mind, who slander the noble ones, who hold wrong views, and who, through such karma of wrong view and through taking up Dharma wrongly, on account of that cause and that condition are born, upon the breaking up of the body at death, in the wretched realms, the lower realms, the state of ruin — in the hells. Or, on the other hand, those sentient beings who conduct themselves rightly in body, who conduct themselves rightly in speech and mind, who do not slander the noble ones, who hold right views, and who, through such karma of right view and through taking up Dharma rightly, on account of that cause and that condition are born, upon the breaking up of the body at death, in the happy realms — in the higher worlds, among the gods — all of this they know fully and precisely as it actually is. Such are the continuity-threads of abiding. Thus the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, with the divine eye that is purified and surpasses that of humans, behold sentient beings as they pass away and are born, beautiful and ugly, high and low —

— beholding those who are beautiful and those who go to the happy realms and those who go to the lower realms, and knowing precisely as it actually is the sentient beings who are passing close to their departure. Among those sentient beings who arise in this way, there are those endowed with misconduct of body, those endowed with misconduct of speech and mind, those who speak falsely against the noble ones, and those who hold wrong views — and on account of the karma of wrong views and of not taking up Dharma rightly, through that cause and that condition, upon the breaking up of the body at death, they will be born in the states of misery, the lower realms, the downfall into ruin, in the hells. Alternatively, among those sentient beings who arise, there are those endowed with right conduct of body, those endowed with right conduct of speech and mind, those who do not speak falsely against the noble ones, and those who hold right views — and through the karma of right view and of taking up Dharma rightly, through that cause and that condition, upon the breaking up of the body at death, they will be born in the happy realms, in the higher worlds, among the gods. All of this they know fully and precisely as it actually is. Such are the continuity-threads of abiding.

Moreover, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, are endowed with this ninth power. Occupying the great station of the lord of the herd, they open wide that station's magnificent expanse, turn the pure wheel of Brahmā, and in the midst of the assembly roar the true lion's

roar.

Furthermore, as additional continuity-threads of abiding, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas — with the exhaustion of all defilements, having liberated the mind that is undefiled, having liberated wisdom, and having directly known and realized the nature of reality visible in this very life by their own direct experience, having brought it to completion — fully know: "Our birth is exhausted. The holy life has been lived. What was to be done has been done. We will not come to know another existence beyond this." Such are the continuity-threads of abiding.

In this way, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas — with the exhaustion of all defilements, having liberated the mind that is undefiled, having liberated wisdom, having directly known and realized the nature of reality visible in this very life by their own direct experience, having brought it to completion — fully know: "Our birth is exhausted. The holy life has been lived. What was to be done has been done. We will not come to know another existence beyond this." Such are the continuity-threads of abiding.

The Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, are endowed with these ten powers. Occupying the great station of the lord of the herd, they open wide that magnificent station, turn the pure wheel of Brahmā, and in the midst of the assembly roar the true lion's roar.

All the buddhas of the past, all the buddhas of the future, and I who have now in the present arisen — all Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas — are equal to one another and without difference: equal in marks, equal and alike in qualities and excellences, equal in the ripened fruit of merit. Yet they are not equal in the three causes of lineage, lifespan, and bodily form.

Then the warriors born in the town of Kuśā addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable one, is there then some other power, more powerful than those powers and able to overwhelm them?" "As for the continuity-threads of abiding: yes, there is another power that is more powerful than those powers and that overwhelms them — namely, the one who at the very midnight of that same night is adorned with marks —

this body adorned with excellent minor marks, and this body-life that serves as the vessel for those powers — the power of impermanence, which will utterly overwhelm them. As for the continuity-threads of abiding: that is the other

power, more powerful than those powers and able to overwhelm them."

Then at that moment the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The power born of body, the power of merit,
the power of wisdom, the power of miraculous ability —
even so, impermanence, which overwhelms my splendor,
is held to be supremely endowed with power.

Wherever there is a body and form like this,
like the summit of a golden mountain's king of peaks,
struck down by the splendor of impermanence —
my dissolution will come to pass.

The power of impermanence is the supreme power:
let the wise fully understand this.
Strive to attain that deathless abode
where impermanence comes no more.

When the warriors born in the town of Kuśā heard this from the Blessed One, they became stupefied and, having lost all ordinary perception, fell backward onto the ground, like so many tree trunks. Some clasped their arms together and wept aloud. Some sat overcome with mental suffering. Some took refuge in the nature of reality alone, thinking: "The Blessed One has declared to us that from all things that were at first desirable, dear, joyous, and pleasing, separation, loss, parting, and deprivation will come to pass."

Then the warriors born in the town of Kuśā, drawing long, soft, flute-like sighs, shed tears, prostrated with their heads to the two feet of the Blessed One, and seated themselves to one side.

Then the Blessed One, together with the Saṅgha of monks, took up his place to one side of that great wide rock. The warriors born in the town of Kuśā likewise seated themselves to one side of that same great wide rock.

Then the Blessed One purified the warriors born in the town of Kuśā as if refining them, and addressed them with these words:

"O continuity-threads of abiding, this great wide rock became the working stone of the people of the first age, which is why even today the traces of their fingers are visible upon it.

O continuity-threads of abiding, all formations (saṃskāra) are impermanent, unstable, unreliable, and subject to change. Sufficiency lies in the very midst

of all formations. They are proper objects of weariness. They are proper objects from which to be free of attachment. They are proper objects of liberation.

O continuity-threads of abiding, the great ocean cannot be drained by four causes. What are those four? Below, it is held in place by a golden wheel that encompasses it on all sides; on its flanks, it is fully encircled by a surrounding rim; from above, the great nāgas cause a stream of rain to fall upon it as plentifully as the axle-poles of chariots; and all the great rivers, accompanied by many thousands of tributaries, flow down into the great ocean. In the same way, this ocean of the Buddha's teaching will not decline by reason of four causes. What are those four? Below, it is held in place by the golden wheel of Vinaya that encompasses it on all sides; on its flanks, it is fully encircled by the surrounding rim of the sūtra collections; it is filled throughout by the rain of the great nāga of Abhidharma;

and it is filled to the brim by the rivers of wholesome roots that arise from meditation. Even so, O beings of abiding lineages, the wholesome roots generated toward the Buddha will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa. The wholesome roots generated toward the Dharma, and the wholesome roots generated toward the Saṅgha, will likewise never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa.

O beings of abiding lineages, this continent of Jambudvīpa measures seven thousand yojanas in breadth and width; it is wide in the north and shaped like a chariot in the south. One may count and measure it as having this many paces, or a hundred paces, or a thousand paces, or a hundred thousand paces. But O beings of abiding lineages, the wholesome roots generated toward the Buddha cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa. The wholesome roots generated toward the Dharma, and the wholesome roots generated toward the Saṅgha, cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa.

O beings of abiding lineages, setting Jambudvīpa aside altogether: the eastern continent called Videha measures eight thousand yojanas in breadth and width, and it is crescent-shaped. One may count and measure it as having this

many paces, or a hundred paces, or a thousand paces, or a hundred thousand paces. But O beings of abiding lineages, the wholesome roots generated toward the Buddha cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa. The wholesome roots generated toward the Dharma, and the wholesome roots generated toward the Saṅgha, cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa.

O beings of abiding lineages, setting aside Jambudvīpa and the eastern continent of Videha: the western continent called Godānīya measures nine thousand yojanas in breadth and width, and it is perfectly round. One may count and measure it as having this many paces, or a hundred paces, or a thousand paces, or a hundred thousand paces. But O beings of abiding lineages, the wholesome roots generated toward the Buddha cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa. The wholesome roots generated toward the Dharma, and the wholesome roots generated toward the Saṅgha, cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa.

O beings of abiding lineages, setting aside Jambudvīpa, the western continent of Godānīya, and the eastern continent of Videha: the northern continent called Uttarakuru measures ten thousand yojanas in breadth and width, and it is perfectly square. One may count and measure it as having this many paces, or a hundred paces, or a thousand paces, or a hundred thousand paces. And

the wholesome roots generated toward a buddha cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa. The wholesome roots generated toward the Dharma, and the wholesome roots generated toward the Saṅgha, cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa.

O beings of abiding lineages, setting aside the world-system of the four continents: there exist the mountain-king ranges, the surrounding mountains and the great surrounding mountains, and even those can be counted and measured as having this many paces, or a hundred paces, or a thousand

paces, or a hundred thousand paces. But, O beings of abiding lineages, the wholesome roots generated toward a buddha cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa. The wholesome roots generated toward the Dharma, and the wholesome roots generated toward the Saṅgha, cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa.

O beings of abiding lineages, setting aside the world-system of the four continents, and setting aside the mountain-king ranges, the surrounding mountains and the great surrounding mountains: the great ocean is eighty thousand yojanas in depth, and its breadth is immeasurable. Even that can be counted and measured as containing this many vase-fulls of water, or a hundred vase-fulls, or a thousand vase-fulls, or a hundred thousand vase-fulls. But, O beings of abiding lineages, the wholesome roots generated toward a buddha cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa. The wholesome roots generated toward the Dharma, and the wholesome roots generated toward the Saṅgha, cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa.

O beings of abiding lineages, setting aside the world-system of the four continents, setting aside the mountain-king ranges, the surrounding mountains and the great surrounding mountains, and setting aside the great ocean: Mount Meru, king of mountains, descends eighty thousand yojanas into the water, and rises eighty thousand yojanas above the water. Even that can be counted and measured as having this many paces, or a hundred paces, or a thousand paces, or a hundred thousand paces. But, O beings of abiding lineages, the wholesome roots generated toward a buddha cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa. The wholesome roots generated toward the Dharma, and the wholesome roots generated toward the Saṅgha, cannot be counted or measured; they will never be exhausted in saṃsāra, will never be fully spent, and will bring the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa.

O beings of abiding lineages, why is this so? It is because the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas are immeasurable in their generosity, immeasurable in their moral discipline, immeasurable in their

patience,

immeasurable in their diligence, immeasurable in their meditative concentration, immeasurable in their wisdom, immeasurable in their miraculous powers, immeasurable in the displays of those miraculous powers, immeasurable in their verbal proclamations, immeasurable in the displays of those verbal proclamations, immeasurable in their instructions, immeasurable in the displays of those instructions, and possessed of the ten powers, the four fearlessnesses, the three unmixed establishments of mindfulness, and immeasurable great compassion. It is for these reasons, O beings of abiding lineages, that the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas are endowed with immeasurable qualities.

When this exposition of Dharma bearing the great lion's roar was proclaimed, the world-system of the great trichiliocosm trembled three times, shook, shook thoroughly, quaked, quaked thoroughly, quaked completely, moved, moved throughout, moved utterly, was stirred, was stirred throughout, and was stirred completely.

Then Brahmā, lord of the assembly, and Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods), each dwelling in his own realm, both thought: "The Blessed One, the buddha, dwells in the vicinity of the city of Kuśa, and by means of great miraculous displays he will soon, without delay, draw the mighty ones born in the city of Kuśa toward him, and then pass into nirvāṇa in the realm of nirvāṇa without remainder. Let us therefore go at once to see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, for this last time." Then Brahmā, lord of the assembly, and Śakra, lord of the gods, vanished from their own realms and appeared in the presence of the Blessed One together with the gods of the desire realm and the gods of the form realm.

Brahmā, lord of the assembly, seated to one side, then offered these verses:

The renowned, perfectly awakened buddhas —
to behold them is exceedingly rare,
like the udumbara flower,
rare to find even in ten million aeons.

You, O Teacher, lion of the Śākyas, supreme among men,
are likewise exceedingly rare to encounter.
Together with the gods of the form realm,
palms pressed together, we bow to you.

Śakra, lord of the gods, seated to one side, then offered these verses:

My eye of Dharma has been purified,
the lamp of Dharma blazes in my heart,
the gates to the lower realms have been closed,
and I have no fear of an evil destiny.
How wondrous is the Teacher, full of compassion,
desiring our benefit, tender of heart!
Together with the gods of the desire realm,
palms pressed together, we bow to you.
You will pass swiftly into nirvāṇa —
this is our last sight of you.

Having thus spoken, Brahmā, lord of the assembly, and Śakra, lord of the gods, prostrated with their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, then departed facing him, their eyes remaining fixed upon him, and prostrating once more, vanished on the spot.

Then the Blessed One, having thoroughly understood the assembly gathered before him — their intentions, their inclinations, their constitutions, and their natures — taught the Dharma in such a way as to cause them to fully realize the four noble truths. Simply upon hearing this, some among the mighty ones born in the city of Kuśa generated wholesome roots that were warm and ripening, some generated the highest wholesome roots, and some generated lesser and middling degrees of patience.

Some generated the supreme Dharma qualities that accord with the truths. Some actualized the fruit of stream-entry. Some actualized the fruit of once-returning. Some actualized the fruit of non-returning. Some went forth into renunciation, abandoned all afflictions, and actualized arhatship itself. Some became those who had generated the mind of awakening directed toward the awakening of a hearer. Some became those who had generated the mind of awakening directed toward solitary awakening. And some became those who had generated the mind of awakening directed toward the unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening.

The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are those who reveal the fruits of Dharma that bear fruit. Of that entire assembly, the greater part came to dwell in a state of being drawn to the Buddha, of alighting on the Dharma, and of rejoicing in the Saṅgha.

This was the last great convening of the Vinaya of the Blessed One.

- The phrase "power born of father and mother" refers to physical strength deriving from one's birth-body — i.e., the natural bodily strength a Tathāgata possesses as a result of his physical birth, as distinguished from his supernatural or meditative powers. This tripartite classification of power recurs throughout the passage as a structural teaching device.

The address "Young ones of stable lineage" renders the Tibetan vocative used for the wrestlers throughout; it is a conventional address to those assembled, indicating they are of a steady, grounded class or clan.

- The passage presents a hierarchical enumeration of strengths through various categories of elephants and increasingly powerful beings, culminating in the strength of the Tathāgata. Several terms in the middle section of the hierarchy, including "great-cluster" beings, "supreme-subduer," "supreme power," "supreme-limbed," and "son of Nanda," are technical terms from what appears to be an ancient Indian cosmological or physiological classification system for grades of physical strength. Their precise referents are not fully transparent from the Tibetan alone; the renderings given reflect the literal Tibetan. "Son of Nanda" renders སྐྱེད་ལོ་ལྷ་མོ་, literally "son of Nanda" or "son of Nandaka," a figure in classical Indian lore renowned for extraordinary physical strength, known in Sanskrit as Nandabala or similar. The phrase ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་ is rendered "of stable lineage," consistent with the preceding passage. The list of elephant types by mountain color and fragrance follows the Tibetan sequence faithfully, though some categories may correspond to known Sanskrit classifications not recoverable from context alone.

- The phrase rendered "lineages of stability" translates ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་, a technical address to the assembled audience. The exact referent is a specialized term within this text's cosmological discourse; it may designate a particular class of beings or a name for the congregation. The rendering follows the literal sense of the Tibetan.

The repeated formula "not within a hundredth part, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not within any fraction, portion, counting, comparison, or calculation" is a standard sūtra amplification sequence; the final term ལྷ་མོ་, rendered "calculation," can also mean "cause" or "approximation," but "calculation" fits the enumerative context best here.

- The Tibetan names of the six desire-realm heavens and their presiding divine figures are rendered here according to their standard cosmological identifications: the Heaven of the Thirty-Three (Trāyastriṃśa), the Heaven Free from Strife (Yāma), Tuṣita, the Heaven Delighting in Emanation (Nirmāṇarati), the Heaven of Those Who Wield Power over Others' Emanations (Paranirmitavaśavartin), and then the transition to the Brahmā realms of the form realm. The "divine son" figures named within each heaven appear to be superlative exemplars or presiding deities of those realms, rendered here by literal translation of their Tibetan epithets, as no single canonical Sanskrit equivalent is determinable from context alone.

- The passage lists the Brahmā-realm heavens in ascending order corresponding to the standard Abhidharma cosmological scheme. "Brahmā Priests" renders the Tibetan term for those who stand before Brahmā as his officiants. "Lord of the Blissful Wheel" renders the Tibetan compound for a specific Brahmā deity title. The rhinoceros simile for the pratyekabuddha is a classical image drawn from the Khaggaviṣāṇa-sutta tradition, indicating solitary practice. The phrase "lineage of the Settled Abode" is a recurring epithet throughout this text for the assembly being addressed; it designates a class of beings or disciples associated with a particular abode or ground. The final sentence begins a new section and is left open as it runs into the next passage.

- The cosmological scheme here follows the standard Buddhist trichiliocosm: a "small thousand" world-system contains one thousand basic units; a "middle two-thousand" contains one thousand of those; and the "great three-thousand" trichiliocosm contains one thousand of the middle systems — yielding one billion basic world-units in total. The Tibetan terms for the four continents are rendered by their conventional Sanskrit equivalents: Uttarakuru (north), Videha (east), Aparagodānīya (west), and Jambudvīpa (south). The final statement that all Buddhas are equal in marks, qualities, and merit but not in lineage, lifespan, and body is a doctrinally significant assertion found in several sūtras and reflects the distinction between

- The term rendered "stratum of elemental essence born of the earth" translates a compound referring to a rich, nutritive essence or flavoring found in the depths of the earth — elsewhere in Pāli and Sanskrit parallels called "earth-essence" or "earth-nutrient" (Skt. *ṛthivī-rasa*). The episode appears to relate to a well-known narrative in which Maudgalyāyana proposes to turn the earth over to expose its nutritive underlayer to feed the starving Saṅgha, and the Buddha famously refuses or redirects him. The phrase "most weightless perception" renders a standard superlative of lightness applied in the tradition to the mental orientation required for great feats of miraculous power — the practitioner perceives the object as utterly insubstantial.
- The cosmological term rendered "the intermediate world-system of two thousand" and "great world-system of the three-thousand-great-thousand" follows the standard Buddhist cosmological schema of a trichiliocosm. The Tibetan reads literally "a thousand of the first-thousand world-system equals the second-thousand intermediate world-system," and a thousand of those equals the three-thousand-great-thousand world-system. This matches the standard Sanskrit *trisāhasramahāsāhasralokadhātu* scheme.

The term "'byung po" rendered as "spirits" can also mean "elemental beings" or "ghosts"; in context alongside sentient beings and living creatures it is used in a general enumerative sense.

The "bull of the herd" renders རྒོམ་གྱི་སྐྲངས། literally "the foremost of the herd" — a standard epithet comparing the Tathāgata to the chief bull, denoting supremacy among beings.

• The term "paths that lead to every destination" renders "thams cad du 'gro ba'i lam," which in the standard Tathāgata-power formulations corresponds to the knowledge of the paths leading to all rebirths or destinies (Skt. sarvatragāminīṃ pratipadaṃ yathābhūtaṃ jānāti). The phrasing "every destination" captures both the literal sense and the doctrinal reference to the various realms of rebirth.

- The phrase rendered "foremost among herds" translates a standard epithet of the Buddha, literally "the supreme of the herd," a traditional simile for the Buddha as a great bull among cattle or the foremost of any group. The "brahmic wheel" (tshangs pa'i 'khor lo) refers here to the wheel of Dharma as a pure, divine, or brahmic turning — the noble Dharma-wheel turned by the Buddha. The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, which reflects the Tibetan source text as given; the translation preserves this natural continuation into the following segment.

- The phrase "the station of the lord of the herd" renders "khy u mchog gi gnas," a standard epithet in this sūtra context meaning the pre-eminent position of the bull-elephant or chief of the herd, used as a simile for the Buddha's unassailable standing in the assembly. The "wheel of Brahmā" refers to the perfectly pure Dharma wheel, with Brahmā evoking purity and transcendence rather than the deity Brahmā specifically.

The passage ends mid-sentence with "adorned with marks," as the Tibetan source itself breaks off at that point. This is not an error in translation but a continuation to be rendered in the next passage.

The doubled paragraph on the exhaustion of defilements appears to be a deliberate textual repetition in the source — a formal anaphoric recapitulation common in sūtra literature — and has been preserved faithfully.

- The phrase rendered "purified them as if refining" translates a verb suggesting a process of cleansing or tempering, as metal is refined. The image is deliberate: the Blessed One subjects the warriors to a kind of purifying instruction after their grief.

The expression "continuity-threads of abiding" is the consistent rendering adopted for the preceding passage's established term for the addressees; it is maintained here as instructed.

- The term འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷན་པོ་ is rendered "O beings of abiding lineages," referring to those who dwell in or belong to one of the established spiritual lineages. The precise doctrinal referent may vary by commentary; some traditions read this as addressing beings of stable or settled gotra.

The four continents are identified by their standard Sanskrit names: Jambudvīpa (south), Videha (east), Godānīya (west), and Uttarakuru (north), corresponding to the Tibetan འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷན་པོ་ of traditional Buddhist cosmology.

The phrase འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷན་པོ་ is literally "will not become fully depleted or exhausted," rendered here as "will never be fully spent" for natural speech flow.

- The term rendered "paces" translates a Tibetan unit of linear measure. In this context the text uses "sraṅ," which is a unit of weight in standard usage, but here functions as a unit for measuring distances and dimensions in a highly stylized cosmological enumeration. The preceding passage used "yojanas" and "paces" as interpretive renderings for similar units; "paces" is retained here for consistency and natural flow, though the underlying term is the same weight-measure used analogically for spatial extent across all the examples in this passage.

- The sixfold earthquake formula used here follows a classical Indic pattern of ascending intensity: shook, shook thoroughly, shook completely, and so on across three synonymous verbs. The rendering preserves this cumulative structure as faithfully as English allows.

The "three unmixed establishments of mindfulness" refers to the Tathāgata's three forms of equanimous mindfulness toward disciples who are attentive, inattentive, or mixed, which are among the eighteen unshared qualities of a buddha; they are called "unmixed" because they are not shared with śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

"Wholesome roots that were warm" renders dro bar gyur pa'i dge ba'i rtsa ba, a technical term from the Abhidharma path-of-preparation framework indicating the stage of heat, the first of four preliminary stages on the path of preparation preceding the path of seeing.

- The phrase rendered "the last great convening of the Blessed One's Vinaya" is slightly ambiguous and could mean either the final great assembly at which the Vinaya was expounded, or the final great gathering governed by the Vinaya. The reading adopted — that

this teaching event constituted the last great convening in connection with the Blessed One's Vinaya — reflects the more natural Tibetan syntax and the narrative context of the passage.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.